

UI

The Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 5 comes with the latest One UI 5.1.1 which runs on top of Android 13. Things just work here. Multiple apps utilise the folding mechanism with Flex Mode, and it just makes sense. For instance, when slightly folded, the camera apps goes from a full screen viewfinder to a half an half screen where one side has the viewfinder, and the other shows your recently snapped pictures.

The transition from the cover screen to full screen is also perfect, with apps picking right up from where you left them on the cover screen. Folding it close will lock the phone and close the app which annoys some, but I think it is the right implementation since you would flip the phone close generally when you're done using it. You also get new multitasking gestures. Simple, sweet, and convenient. Do remember that these gestures are turned off by default and you would have to go into Advanced Features in Settings to turn them on.

CAMERAS

Let's talk about the cameras. You've got a 50 MP primary shooter with Optical Image Stabilisation and Dual Pixel PDAF, there's a 12 MP ultrawide camera, and a 10 MP telephoto shooter with OIS and 3x optical zoom support. The inner display has an under-display 4 MP selfie camera – and because it lies under a bunch of pixels, the results look like they've come straight out of a 2016-2018 selfie camera. Just avoid using it altogether for selfies. Instead use the 10 MP selfie shooter on the cover screen, or better yet, the primary camera with the cover screen as a viewfinder.

Using the primary camera for selfies, you're going to get some of the most crisp shots – with excellent detail retention, fantastic low light performance, and good colour.

Now, let's speak about the primary camera in general. Photos taken from this camera look great in daylight – impressive dynamic range, vibrant and saturated colours (typical of Samsung devices), and great detail retention. Por-

traits have fantastic edge detection and good clarity as well. The 12 MP ultrawide camera loses out on some dynamic range but has minimal barrel distortion.

Shots from the telephoto lens also look amazing, and the colour profile mimics the primary shooter which is always a great thing to see. The pictures look very similar to the ones taken from the Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 4, with a bit of extra sharpness in low light shots.

Speaking of low light optics, it's a bit of a hit or miss. Detail and sharpness are good, colours look natural, but there's quite a lot of haloing around objects and general lens flare in low light. It's not just a one-off, I experienced this in almost every picture I took in low light. Additionally, the lens tends to capture soft shots of moving subjects in low light. Overall, these are some of the best cameras on a foldable today, but they're not perfect. And if the Google Pixel Fold shows up in India, the Samsung Galaxy Z Fold5 could lag behind considerably in terms of optics.

BATTERY LIFE

The battery capacity of the Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 5 remains unchanged. You get a 4,400 mAh battery but the uptick we saw in battery life was quite substantial. This must be due to improved efficiency because of the Snapdragon 8 Gen 2 chipset. The Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 5 easily lasts for a day without needing a top-up. In fact, after a day consisting of benchmarking, clicking photos, editing pictures, watching videos, and browsing social media, the phone still had a good 22 per cent battery left by 10 PM.

In our 4K video loop test, the Samsung Galaxy Z Fold5 lasted a whopping 19 hours and 6 minutes. That's almost 3 hours more than the Galaxy Z Fold4 lasted in the same test. So, expect superb battery life that should keep you coasting for long enough without picking up the charger.

A charger you'd have to likely spend extra for because you don't get one in the retail box *sigh*. The Z Fold 5 supports 25 W wired charging, which is laboriously slow in 2023. The phone took 1 hour and

18 minutes to charge from empty to full, which doesn't compete with flagship phones from Xiaomi, OnePlus, and Vivo. You do get 15 W wireless charging support as well, which is a good thing. Also, there's 4.5 W reverse wireless charging which is handy to top off TWS earbuds with wireless charging support.

VERDICT

The Samsung Galaxy Z Fold 5 is the best foldable of its type out there – yes, despite the miniscule incremental improvements. The foldable formula Samsung has carried through the years is getting refined and polished with every iteration, so much so that this is the absolute best and most versatile folding software experience you can get your hands on. Add to that, blazing fast performance, impressive battery life, and good cameras – you've got yourselves the best foldable in 2023. However, Samsung cannot keep teetering the edge with incremental upgrades since there are too many OEMs out there that are improving by leaps and bounds every year – coming very close to snatching that 'Best Foldable' crown. They cannot get away with slow charging, the hard-to-use cover screen aspect ratio, inconsistent low light camera performance for very long, so I do hope the next Z Fold out of the South Korean giant is something truly revolutionary.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Qualcomm Snapdragon 8 Gen 2 for Galaxy | RAM: 12 GB LPDDR5X | ROM: upto 1 TB UFS 4.0 | Inner display: 7.6-inch Dynamic AMOLED 2X, 120 Hz, 2176 x 1812 pixels | Cover display: 6.2-inches, Dynamic AMOLED 2X, 120 Hz, 904 x 2316 pixels | Cover display protection: Corning Gorilla Glass Victus 2 | OS: Android 13, One UI 5.1.1 | S-Pen support: Yes | Cameras (rear): 50 MP main + 12 MP ultrawide + 10 MP telephoto | Cameras (selfie): 4 MP (inner screen, under display) + 10 MP (cover screen) | Weight: 253 g | IP Rating: IPX8 | Battery capacity: 4,400 mAh | Charging: 25 W (wired), 15 W (wireless), 4.5 W (reverse wireless)

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